Grammatical Features
based largely on Goddard (2005) Chapter 4.

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2026

Overview

1. Word order
2. Classifiers
3. Aspect
4. Serial Verbs
5. Subject and Topic
6. Sentence Final Particles (SFP)

Outline

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Two Word-Order Types Meet in East Asia

	Japanese, Korean	Mandarin	Thai, Malay, Viet.
verb, object	OV	VO	VO
adposition	postposition	preposition	preposition
relative clause	Rel N	Rel N	N Rel
possessor	Poss N	Poss N	N Poss

- The features **line up**: OV languages put modifiers before the noun, VO languages after it
- Mandarin is the odd one out: VO, but relative clauses come first

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Counting Needs a Classifier

			order
Thai	*măa săam tua*	dog three CLF	N Num Clf
Malay	*tiga ekor anjing*	three CLF dog	Num Clf N
Vietnamese	*ba con chó*	three CLF dog	Num Clf N
Mandarin	*sān zhī gǒu*	three CLF dog	Num Clf N
Japanese	*san-biki no inu*	three-CLF of dog	Num Clf N
	inu san-biki	dog three-CLF	N Num Clf

- Required with numerals and with vague quantifiers like “many”, “some”
- Number and classifier form a **phrase**, which can stand alone

Why Have Classifiers?

- Nouns name **kinds**, like English *rice* or *water*: to count, you need a **unit**
- The classifier **individuates**: *three head of cattle*, *two sheets of paper*
- Classifier languages rarely have **obligatory plural** marking

Inventories are shrinking: younger speakers lean on the general classifier (Mandarin *gè*, Japanese *-tsu*)

Thai: The Classifier Phrase Stands Alone

(1) Mǎa kìi tua?
dog how.many CLF:animal
"How many dogs?" [tha]

(2) (Mǎa) sǎam tua.
(dog) three CLF:animal
"Three (dogs)." [tha]

Malay: The Same, in a Different Order

(3) Berapa ekor anjing?
how.many CLF:animal dog
"How many dogs?" [zsm]

(4) Tiga ekor (anjing).
three CLF:animal (dog)
"Three (dogs)." [zsm]

Four Kinds of Counting Word

kind	counts	example
sortal	individuals	*san-satsu no hon* “three books”
mensural	amounts	*ni-hai no mizu* “two cups of water”
group	collections	*two pairs of shoes*
repeater	by the noun itself	Thai *taw* “vase”

Sortal classifiers apply across the whole lexicon; the others are limited

What Gets Classified?

basis	example
kind	human, animal, tree
function	cutting, writing, eating and drinking
shape	long (1D), flat (2D), round (3D)
consistency	rigid, flexible
size	finger-sized, hand-sized, person-sized
location	towns, buildings
arrangement	row, coil, heap
quanta	head, pack, flock

Shape and kind are the most common bases across languages (Allan, 1977)

Japanese *-tsu*: The General Classifier

used	example
for the residue	*yume-o hito-tsu mita* "I had a dream"
as a default	*hon-o chōdo hito-tsu katta* "I bought exactly one book"
when the thing is vague	*nantoka-ga hito-tsu hoshii* "I want one thingamajig"

Sortal classifiers pick out **kind** or **shape**; the general one is used when nothing is salient (Bond and Paik, 2011)

Measure and Group Words

(5) 二 杯 の 水
ni hai no mizu
two CLF.cup of water
“two cups of water” [jpn]

a flock of birds *a herd of cows*
a mob of protestors *two bunches of bananas*

Group words are common in English and Thai, rarer in Japanese

Repeaters: The Noun Is Its Own Classifier

(6) Mii taw dòòk-maj cak taw?
there.is vase flower how.many vase
"How many vases are there?" [tha]

Common in Thai and Lao, especially when no classifier exists for the noun

Classifiers Can Show Respect

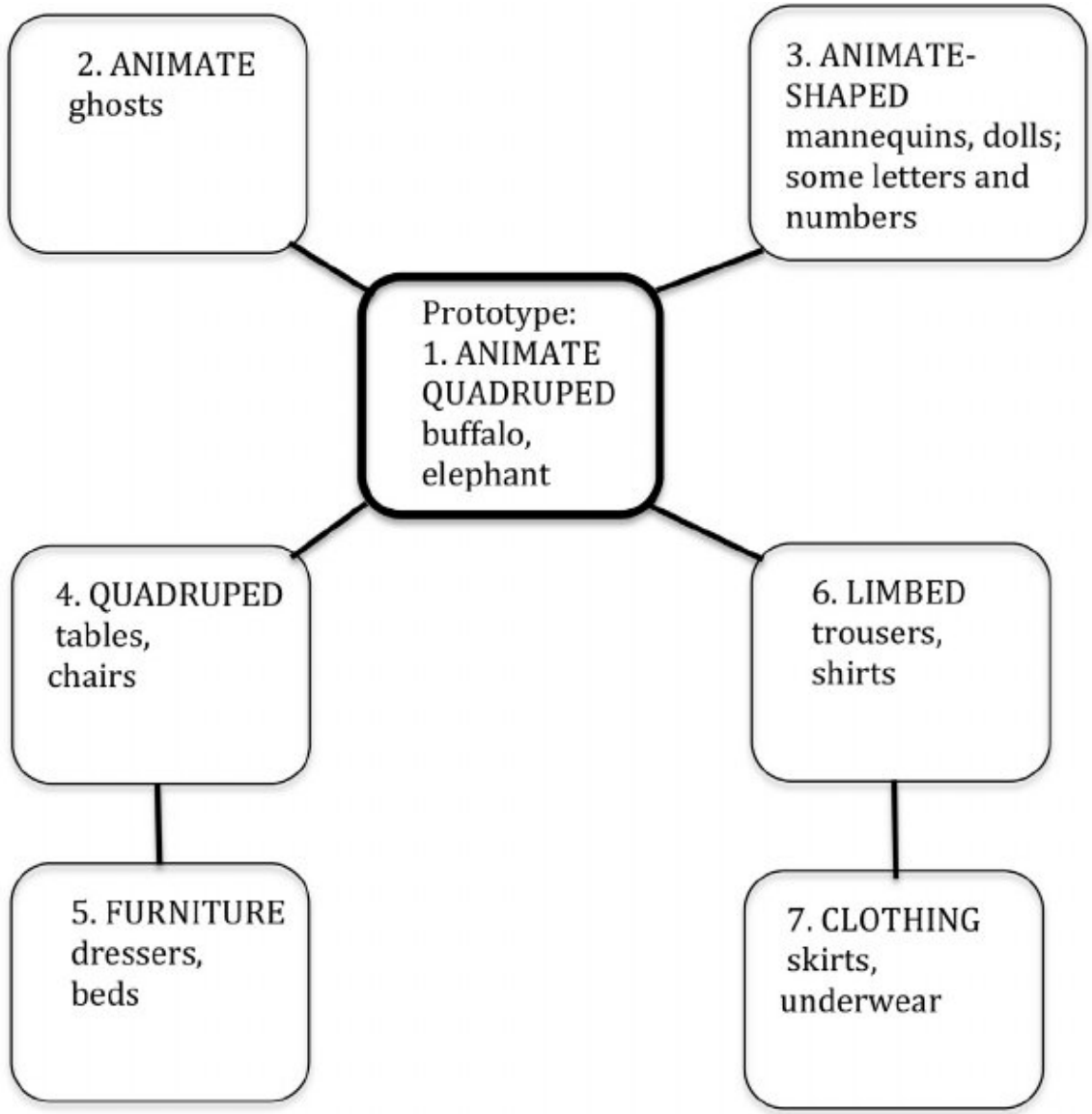
"three people"	plain	honorific
Japanese	三人 *san-nin*	三名様 *san-mei-sama*
Korean	세 명 *se myeong*	세 분 *se bun*

(7) 何　名　　様　　です か
nan　mei　　sama desu　ka
what CLF.person HON　is　Q
"How many in your party?" [jpn]

Khmer has special classifiers for royalty and monks

A Classifier Is a Radial Category

Thai *tua*: animals at the centre, extended to furniture and clothing (things with legs or a body)



Japanese and Chinese Sort Nouns Differently

referents	Japanese			Mandarin		
uncountable	—		29%	—		28%
events	回	*-kai*	26%	次	*cì*	26%
general	つ	*-tsu*	21%	个	*gè*	24%
people	人	*-nin*	11%	位	*wèi* (HON)	3%
concrete objects	個	*-ko*	5%	块	*kuài* (lumps)	2%
long thin	本	*-hon*	2%	条	*tiáo*	1%
flat	枚	*-mai*	1%	张	*zhāng*	1%
drops of liquid	滴	*-teki*	1%	滴	*dī*	1%
classifiers used	47			81		

- Default classifiers for 2,710 semantic classes in an ontology (Goi-Taikei), assigned by hand
- Mandarin has more, and more specific, classifiers; Japanese leans on *-tsu* and *-ko*
- 20% of classes take more than one: weapons are *-chō* (knives), *-hon* (long), *-furi* (swords), *-ki* (machines)

Classifiers Can Count Indirectly

(8) 2-tsū-no denshimēru
2-tong-ui imeil
2-CLF.message-of email
"2 emails" [jpn, kor]

(9) 3-mai-no tegami
3-chang-ui pyeonji
3-CLF.flat-of letter
"a 3-page letter", not "3 letters" [jpn, kor]

(Bond and Paik, 1997)

Noun Classes Are Not Classifiers

	noun classes	numeral classifiers
number	2–20, closed	30–80 in use
realization	inflection	separate word
marked	on many words	in the noun phrase
examples	German, Bantu	Mandarin, Thai, Malay

Gender is a noun class system: *der Hund* "the (M) dog", *das Mädchen* "the (N) girl" (Dixon, 1986)

Swahili: The Noun Class Marks the Whole Sentence

(10) Vi-su vi-dogo vi-wili hi-vi amba-vy-o ni-li-vi-nunua ni vi-kali.
8-knife 8-small 8-two this-8 which-8-REL 1SG-PST-8-buy be 8-sharp
"These two small knives which I bought are sharp." [swh]

Class 8 (plural objects) is marked on adjectives, numerals, demonstratives, relatives and the verb — a classifier appears only once, next to the number

Adapted from Saeed (2009, 181), citing Allan (2001, 310)

Your Turn: How Would You Count These?

- Does a language you speak classify nouns? On what basis?
- Which classifier (or gender) would you use for:
  - a *watermelon*
  - a *grain* of rice
  - a *person*, a *teacher*, a *guest*
  - a *robot*

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New things get classified by **shape**, by **function**, or fall back to the **general** classifier

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Aspect, Not Tense

tense *when* did it happen?
aspect *how* does it unfold?

- Many East and Southeast Asian languages have no tense
- They mark aspect instead: suffixes, auxiliaries, particles

Kinds of Aspect

perfective	the whole event	*She ran home*
imperfective:	the inside of the event	
progressive	ongoing	*She is running*
iterative	repeated	*The light is flashing*
durative	taking time	*He was sitting*
habitual	regular	*She runs every morning*

Aspect Markers in Mandarin and Cantonese

	Mandarin		Cantonese	
perfective	V-*le*	了	V-*zo2*	咗
progressive	*zài*-V	在	V-*gan2*	緊
continuous	V-*zhe*	着	V-*zyu6*	住
experiential	V-*guo*	过	V-*gwo3*	過
delimitative	V-*yi*-V	一	V-*haa5*	吓
habitual			V-*hoi1*	開

Aspect marking is independent of time reference

Mandarin *-le*: Completion, Not Past

(11) Tā kāi-le mén, nǐ jiù jìn-qu.
3SG open-PFV door 2SG then enter-go
"(Once) she opens the door, you go in." [cmn]

(12) Nǐ gāo-le yìdiǎn.
2SG tall-PFV a.little
"You've got (a little) taller." [cmn]

-le works for future and conditional events, and with stative verbs

Cantonese: Progressive and Experiential

(13) Wong4 siu2ze2 gong2-gan2 din6waa2.
Wong miss talk-PROG telephone
"Miss Wong is talking on the phone." [yue]

(14) Lei5 hai2 Hoeng1gong2 zyu6-gwo3 gei2noi6 aa3?
2SG in Hong.Kong live-EXP how.long SFP
"How long did you live in Hong Kong?" [yue]

Cantonese: Habitual *-hoi1*

(15) Keoi5 zou6-hoi1 zung1dim2 ge3.
3SG work-HAB part.time SFP
"She normally works part-time." [yue]

(16) Keoi5 ji5cin4 zaa1-hoi1 Ben1si2 ge3.
3SG before drive-HAB Benz SFP
"She used to drive a Mercedes." [yue]

Regular or customary actions, present or past

Cantonese: Delimitative *-haa5* "for a while"

(17) Tai2-haa5.
look-DEL
"Have a look." [yue]

(18) Jau1sik1-haa5.
rest-DEL
"Have a rest." [yue]

English uses *have a* V: *have a look*, *have a walk*

Malay: Aspect Words Before the Verb

(19) Saya pun sudah beritahu juga semalam.
1SG FOC PFV tell also yesterday
"I already told (you) yesterday." [zsm]

(20) Bila saya masuk, dia sedang membaca.
when 1SG enter 3SG PROG read
"When I came in, they were reading." [zsm]

sudah marks completion, for past *or* future events; *sedang* marks ongoing action

Singlish Carries the Pattern into English

perfect	*Eat already?*	"Have you eaten?"
experiential	*I eat durian before.*	"I've had durian before."
habitual	*He always late one.*	"He's always late."
continuative	*Your phone still spoil ah?*	"Still broken?"

Singapore Colloquial English uses English words as aspect markers

Summary: Aspect

- Aspect, not tense, is the core time category
- Marked by **suffixes** (Sinitic) or **words before the verb** (Malay)
- Perfective, progressive, experiential, habitual, delimitative

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Serial Verbs: Several Verbs, One Clause

- Two or more verbs, **no conjunction**, one subject

loose	a sequence of events	own arguments
tight	a single event	motion, posture

Loose Serialization: A Sequence of Events

(21) Dèèng paj³ talaat⁵ sùù⁴ khùang¹ maa² hùan² lèèw⁴.
Deng go market buy stuff come house PFV
"Deng went to the market, bought some stuff, (and) came home."
[lao]

One perfective marker covers the whole sequence

Tight Serialization: One Event

(22) Dèk wîng pay síi khanŏm.
child run go buy candy
"The child ran (and) bought candy." [tha]

The verbs share their subject and describe a single unitary event

Pragmatics Decides What Counts as One Event

(23) nang¹ tii³ lanaat⁴.
sit beat lanaat
"Play the lanaat sitting." [lao]

(24) ? nòòn² tii³ lanaat⁴.
lie beat lanaat
"Play the lanaat lying down." [lao]

Nobody plays the lanaat lying down — unless the context makes it sensible

Come and Go Give the Direction

(25) Khăw klàp maa lέεw.
3SG return come PFV
"She came back already." [tha]

(26) Khăw klàp pay lέεw.
3SG return go PFV
"She went back already." [tha]

Directional verbs work like adverbs: "hither", "away"

Three Verbs: Manner, Path, Deixis

(27) Laaw² ñaang¹ khùn⁵ maa².
3SG walk go.up come
"She walked up here." [lao]

ñaang¹	walk	manner of motion
khùn⁵	go up	absolute direction
maa²	come	towards the speaker

Verbs That Work as Prepositions

(28) Laaw² nùng¹ khaw⁵ haj⁵ khòòj⁵.
3SG steam rice give(=for) 1SG
"He steamed some rice for me." [lao]

(29) Khan² haw² juu¹ nam² mèè¹-thaw⁵.
if 1PL live accompany(=with) mother-old
"If we live with your mother." [lao]

"give" marks the beneficiary, "accompany" the companion

Vietnamese: “Arrive” Means “About”

(30) Chúng tôi nhắc đến anh luôn.
PL 1EXCL recall arrive(=about) brother often
“We often speak about you.” [vie]

Serial verbs can mark what is being talked about

Japanese Compound Verbs Form a Cline

		literally	means
lexical	取り締まる *tori-shimaru*	take-squeeze	manage
aspectual	書き上げる *kaki-ageru*	write-raise	write up
	歩き出す *aruki-dasu*	walk-out	start walking
syntactic	食べ終わる *tabe-owaru*	eat-finish	finish eating
	歩き始める *aruki-hajimeru*	walk-begin	start walking

The aspectual ones are like English particle verbs (Hashimoto and Bond, 2005)

Arguments Can Transfer

大阪を食べ歩く *Ōsaka-o tabe-aruku*

Osaka-ACC eat-walk

“stroll around Osaka eating”

寿司を食べ歩く *sushi-o tabe-aruku*

sushi-ACC eat-walk

“stroll around eating sushi”

The object can belong to either verb

Summary: Serial Verbs

- Several verbs, one subject, no conjunction
- **Loose**: a sequence; **tight**: one event
- They express direction, beneficiaries, companions — the work prepositions do in English

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What Makes an English Subject?

before the verb	*She seems happy.*
its own case	*I* vs *me*, *they* vs *them*
verb agreement	*he goes*
passive promotes	*Maxine was elected.*
any role	agent, patient, experiencer

European languages add case and person-number agreement; the traditional view is that every language has subjects

Topic: What the Sentence Is About

- In English, topic and subject usually coincide: *Cats eat mice.*
- In many Asian languages they **diverge**
- There, **topic** may matter more than subject

Thai: Topic First

(31) Pàakphanang khâaw raw kin ngâay.
Pakphanang rice 1PL eat simple
"(In) Pakphanang, we ate simply." [tha]

- Typically SVO, but OSV and SOV are common in informal speech
- Subjects are often left out; order follows the discourse

Mandarin: Topic First

(32) Zhāngsān wǒ yǐjīng jiàn-guo le.
Zhangsan 1SG already see-EXP CRS
"Zhangsan, I've already seen (him)." [cmn]

- Topics always come first; times and places are often topics: *In Taipei, one can eat well*
- Subjects are left out when context is clear

Mandarin: Topic *and* Subject

(33) Xiàng bízi cháng.
elephant nose long
"Elephants, (their) noses are long." [cmn]

The topic sets the frame; the comment has its own subject. This is ordinary, not marked

Japanese: *wa* Marks Topic, *ga* Subject

(34) Hi wa nobor-u.
sun TOP rise-PRS
"The sun rises." (general) [jpn]

(35) Hi ga nobor-u.
sun NOM rise-PRS
"The sun is rising." (this one) [jpn]

wa: generic or contrastive, and for times and places; *ga*: the event as a whole

Tagalog: The Verb Says Which Role the Trigger Has

(36) B<um>ili ang lalaki ng isda sa tindahan.
<AT>buy TRIG man GEN fish LOC store
"The man bought (some) fish at the store." [tgl]

(37) B<in>ili ng lalaki ang isda sa tindahan.
<PT>buy GEN man TRIG fish LOC store
"The man bought the fish at the store." [tgl]

Same event, same roles: the affix (*-um-* actor, *-in-* patient) says which role the **trigger** (*ang*) NP plays (Schachter, 1976)

Tagalog: Any Role Can Be the Trigger

trigger	sentence
actor	*Bumili ang lalaki ng isda sa tindahan.* "The man bought fish at the store"
patient	*Binili ng lalaki ang isda sa tindahan.* "The man bought the fish at the store"
location	*Binilhan ng lalaki ng isda ang tindahan.* "The man bought fish at the store"
beneficiary	*Ibinili ng lalaki ng isda ang bata.* "The man bought fish for the child"

- The trigger is definite: *ng isda* "(some) fish" vs *ang isda* "the fish"
- Only the trigger can be relativized: *ang isda-ng binili ng lalaki* "the fish that the man bought"
- It acts like a subject, but any role can fill it — neither subject nor topic quite fits

Acehnese: Actor and Undergoer

(38) Geu-jak.
3-go
"(S)he goes." [ace]

(39) Lôn rhët-lôn.
1SG fall-1SG
"I fall." [ace]

Prefixes mark **actors**, suffixes mark **undergoers** — not subject and object

Summary: Subject and Topic

- European languages are **subject**-prominent; East Asian languages **topic**-prominent
- Topic and subject need not coincide
- Tagalog and Acehnese question whether subjects are universal

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Particles Carry the Speaker's Attitude

- At the **end** of the sentence
- Speech acts: asking, requesting, persuading
- Feelings: surprise, doubt, hesitation

	one every	particles
Cantonese	1.5 seconds	30+, in 100+ combinations
Mandarin	6 seconds	about 7 common ones

Like English intonation, but explicit. Common in Thai, Lao and Vietnamese too; rarer in formal and written language

Some Cantonese Particles

呀	*aa1*	lively statement, question
呀	*aa2*	seeking confirmation
噢	*ak1*	abrupt disagreement
啦	*laa1*	requesting, seeking agreement
囉	*lo3*	emphasizing the current situation
咩	*me1*	surprise
喎	*wo3*	informative, noteworthy
嘩	*bo3*	exclamatory
喇	*laa3*	current relevance, advice
咋	*zaa3*	cheeky, intimate

Cantonese: Particles in Questions

(40) Lei5 gu2 gam3 jung4ji6 aa2?
2SG guess so easy SFP
"You think it's that easy, do you?" [yue]

aa2	surprise or disapproval
haa2	presupposing agreement
me1	surprise, often rhetorical

Cantonese: Directive Particles

(41) Taai3 cou4 laa3, ngo5 fan3 m4 dou2.
too noisy SFP 1SG sleep not able
"It's too noisy, I can't sleep." [yue]

(42) Gam2 zau6 dak1 lo3.
so then okay SFP
"That'll be all right, won't it?" [yue]

laa3: current relevance; *lo3*: invites agreement

Mandarin Particles

(43) Nǐ xǐhuan chī ma?
2SG like eat Q
"Do you like to eat (it)?" [cmn]

(44) Wǒmen qù ba.
1PL go SFP
"Let's go." [cmn]

(45) Tā ne?
3SG SFP
"What about him?" [cmn]

Singlish Particles (1)

You must go lah.	"You must go, okay?"
I already said lor.	"I already told you, see?"
This one easy mah.	"This one is easy, you know?"
You sure can do it meh?	"Are you really sure?"

Chow et al. (2024)

Singlish Particles (2)

Don't blame me what.	"It's not my fault, you know?"
She always like that one.	"She's always like that, you know?"
Your friend leh¹?	"What about your friend?" (question)
Eh, don't like that leh³.	"Don't be like that." (persuasive)

The tone of *leh* changes its meaning

Conclusions

- **Classifiers** are needed to count, and sort nouns by kind, shape and status
- **Aspect**, not tense, organizes time
- **Serial verbs** do the work of prepositions and adverbs
- **Topic** can matter more than subject
- **Particles** carry the speaker's attitude

Southeast Asian languages package meaning differently from European ones

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